Dieter Veldsman
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Work for Humans

Building Sustainable Employee Experience Strategies

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Introduction

Post-pandemic, we've seen a shift towards more human-centric workplaces. Employees are balancing the scales in terms of what they want from work and what they expect from employers. With growing global talent shortages and skills deficits, organizations must respond to ensure they can attract and retain the desired people who can deliver on the business strategy. Several companies are referring to people-first cultures or more human practices, but this will be put to the test by the actual lived experiences of the employees. Social media gives employees a voice in the public domain and allows employees to provide anonymous feedback on the experience of work at their employers.

For some organizations, this is an excellent opportunity to show the world why they are a desirable employer; for others, this is a wake-up call that they are not living up to employees' standards. Many employees are voting with their feet, leaving their organizations to seek greener pastures in what is referred to as the Great Resignation or the Great Reshuffle. Leaders and HR have to respond to this changing requirement, and we have started to shift to become architects of the human experience. In this role, we will have to focus on becoming employee experience designers who shape workplaces where people want to work, want to stay, and want to contribute.

This book aims to provide a practitioner perspective on Employee Experience design and how to implement the practice successfully. As authors, in our experience, the current literature on employee experience falls into two camps, and through our contribution, we aim to bridge the gap. On one side, we find the academic contribution that seeks to define employee experience and its positioning amidst employee engagement, value proposition, and satisfaction. On the other side of the spectrum, you find the growing number of practitioners proposing activities and methods such as design thinking as the basis of designing meaningful experiences. Both perspectives are valuable, but as self-proclaimed pracademics, we have struggled to find a methodology incorporating the required research on the subject with a practical implementation methodology. As such, we developed our own over the past 5 years. This book is the culmination of our findings, lessons, and

guidelines on driving meaningful, evidence-based, tested, and impactful employee experiences within your organization.

We have organized the book into five themes. Theme One provides context to the human-centered design and employee experience movement with a critical focus on the business case for employee experience. Theme Two positions our Employee Experience model, framework, methodology, and practitioner tools that can be utilized to drive employee experiences in practice. Theme Three discusses various case studies of how the methodology has been applied, including relevant learnings and guidelines. Theme Four will discuss building an EX capability and the skills required to successfully operationalize employee experience within organizations of varying sizes and complexity. We end the book with Theme Five, a perspective on the future of employee experience, and express our ambitions for the practice and how we believe it can contribute towards sustainable and engaging work.

Our purpose with this book is to ensure a guidebook based upon sound theoretical underpinnings that practitioners can trust when implementing employee experience strategies.

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Chapter 1
The Rise of Employee Experience (EX) as a Human-Centric Approach to Work



1.1 Introduction

The world of work has undergone a profound transformation over the past decade, reshaping our collective understanding of what work means, where it happens, and its role in our lives (Blustein et al., 2023). These changes have fundamentally altered the employer–employee relationship, giving rise to new expectations from employers and employees, who demand a rethinking of traditional organizational practices (Fraccaroli et al., 2024). In this context, EX has emerged as a critical field within HRM, offering a human-centric approach to designing work environments that prioritize employees' unique needs, expectations, engagement, and satisfaction (Malik et al., 2023).

This chapter explores the evolution of work, the rise of the experience economy and the human-centric movement, the changes to and redefinition of the psychological contract, and the growing importance of EX as a driver of business success.

1.2 The Evolution of Work

Over the past decade, several factors have transformed work, including technological innovation, globalization, and changing workforce demographics (Germain, 2021). Historically, work was defined by rigid structures and clear boundaries between individuals' personal and professional lives and was often tied to physical office spaces (Steffens et al., 2023). This traditional model emphasized stability, routine, and hierarchy, with employees expected to trade their time and labor for financial compensation. However, the last decade has seen a seismic

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Table 1.1 The changing dynamic of work (Veldsman & Van der Merwe, 2022a)

Aspect of work	Past world	Current world	Future world
Who will do the work?	Permanent employees and service providers	A hybrid workforce of permanent, gig, and contract workers, with automation of processes and in-sourcing of services where required	Crowd- and open-source workforces with varying employment conditions and relationships, augmented by technology and artificial intelligence (AI)
Where will they do the work?	On site	Multiple sites owned or leased by the organization and location-bound remote workplaces	Offices, homes, third spaces (e.g., shared workspaces, coffee shops), and virtual workspaces
When will they do the work?	Work hours	Flexible hours	Anytime
How will work be delivered?	Physically	Physically and digitally	Digitally, physically, and virtually
How is work perceived?	Activity to survive or progress	Vocation to engage and deliver value	Pursuit of meaning and purpose
What is the human contribution?	Effort and hands	Knowledge and experience	Expertise and skills

shift in how work is conceptualized and performed (Kanwal et al., 2024). The rise of digital technologies, including communication tools, has been a primary driver of this transformation. Remote work, once a rarity, has become commonplace, enabling employees to work from anywhere and at any time (De Araújo Vitória et al., 2022).

This shift was accelerated by the COVID-19 pandemic, which forced many organizations to adopt remote work on an unprecedented scale. A McKinsey (2020) study found that more than 20% of the workforce could continue working remotely 3–5 days per week, leading to a potential shift in the future geography of work and the real-estate market. The changing dynamic of work is summarized in Table 1.1.

Additionally, the growing importance of a work–life balance and the desire for flexible working arrangements have redefined the relationship between employers and employees. According to a survey by PwC (2021), 83% of employees identified work–life balance as a top priority when choosing an employer, reflecting a broader scope of employee values. Work is increasingly seen as a source of personal fulfillment and identity rather than just a means of financial security. These changes necessitated a rethinking of traditional HR practices and laid the foundation for the emergence of EX as a critical focus for organizations (Panneerselvam & Balaraman, 2022).

1.3 The Experience Economy and Human-Centric Movement

The rise of the experience economy has been a significant response to the changing nature of work and organizations. Pine and Gilmore (1998) first introduced the concept of the experience economy in 1998, arguing an awareness that we are moving beyond the service economy to an economy where experiences are becoming the key offering.

A decade ago, organizations differentiated themselves through products and services. However, with technological advances leveling the playing field, there has been a shift toward creating memorable customer experiences. The rise of the experience economy intensified this renewed focus on recognizing and prioritizing the needs and preferences of customers. Customers now expect more personalized and tailored experiences from the brands with which they interact. This necessitates that organizations understand the needs of their customers and respond to these expectations by designing products, services, and experiences that resonate with their target audience. In this new economy, value is created through products and services, as well as the experiences organizations deliver to their customers. This shift in mindset has also transcended the customer experience domain and entered the domain of employee experiences, highlighting a similar need for consideration of the wants, needs, and desires of human-beings in the workplace. These movements have fueled the human-centric movement, which emphasizes the importance of understanding and prioritizing the human aspects of work.

Human-centricity is the fundamental principle of putting people at the heart of business decisions, work practices, and human–technology interaction (Alves et al., 2023). It reflects a deliberate choice and way of doing business to create mutual value and acknowledge the unique contribution of humans to work. This means that organizations cannot be externally human-centric if they do not have an internal human-centric culture supported by human-centric practices.

Both the experience economy and the human-centric movement have led to fundamental shifts in how organizations think about and engage with customers and employees. These shifts have profound implications for how organizations are designed and operated and for their competitive advantage and viability in the future. We see five distinct considerations for organizations in this new experience-driven world:

1.3.1 From Selling Products to Delivering Experiences

One of the most significant developments associated with the experience economy and human-centric movement is the shift from selling products, goods, and services to creating memorable experiences aligned with the unique needs of end

users (Pine & Gilmore, 1998). Regardless of industry or market, the implication for organizations is that they have to design and orchestrate experiences that engage customers in a personal and memorable way. These experiences then become the differentiating value offered by organizations to their customers, consumers, and end users.

Similarly, employees want a consumer-like experience at work when engaging with employee value propositions, technologies, and daily interactions. To meet these needs, organizations have to approach the design of work, workplaces, and employment in a different manner.

1.3.2 Personalization and Customization as the Norm

Both the experience economy and the human-centric movement emphasize the importance of personalization (Schmitt, 1999). Personalization refers to how organizations understand and prioritize the unique needs of their customers in designing and delivering products and solutions. Whether customizing products and services for customers or tailoring experiences and interactions with the brand, personalization is key to creating value. For many organizations, this shift is supported by technological advancements that allow for mass customization and data-driven insights into the needs and behaviors of their end users.

Employees are also seeking more personalization that accommodates their personal needs. A strong focus on aspects of work-life balance, remote working, and choice benefits is prime examples of how organizations are incorporating more personalization in the work experience.

1.3.3 Focusing on Engagement and Immersion

Engagement and immersion with regard to products and services are central to the experience economy and human-centric movements. Beyond designing personalized and customized experiences, the experiences deliver value by captivating consumers and immersing them in an engaging experience (Prahalad, 2004). For consumers, this increases interaction with the products and services offered, creates a connection with the organization and brand, and leads to increased satisfaction and loyalty.

Employees are also seeking an employer that aligns to their values and purpose, giving them meaning as part of the work relationship. A stronger focus on organizational culture, work engagement, and experience has become crucial aspects of talent strategies.

1.3.4 A Holistic and Integrated Approach

The experience economy and human-centric movement advocate a holistic view of human needs, encompassing physical, emotional, and psychological aspects (Norman, 2004). This approach recognizes that customer experiences are influenced by multiple touchpoints, requiring organizations to integrate various aspects of their operations to create a seamless and positive experience. For customers, these experiences are shaped from the moment of first interaction, throughout various interactions across their consumer lifecycle, facilitated by both human and technological modes of interaction.

The employee lifecycle has become an important part of managing employees in a more holistic and end to end manner. The lifecycle identifies various stages of employment and practices with which the employee engages and aims to create memorable moments to drive satisfaction and engagement.

1.3.5 Value Co-creation and Mutual Benefit

In the experience economy, value is cocreated through interactions between the organization and the customer. Rather than being passive recipients, customers are active participants in the experience, investing energy and contributions through their interactions with members of the organization. This co-creation process is essential to delivering unique and personalized experiences that resonate deeply and foster a sense of connection. This shift is encapsulated in human-centered design, which has become the gold standard for organizations that strive to remain relevant, competitive, and sustainable in a volatile context (Veldsman & Van der Merwe, 2022a).

Co-creation and collaboration have become two important distinguishing factors of the workplace today. Organizations specifically focus on incorporating employee feedback into the workplace, with more robust and always-on listening strategies becoming the norm.

A human-centric culture prioritizes the needs, values, and well-being of individuals, emphasizing empathy, inclusivity, and engagement. It challenges traditional management models that prioritize efficiency and control over the holistic well-being of employees. A human-centric organization seeks to understand its employees' lived experiences and designs work environments that support their employees' physical, emotional, and psychological needs.

In short, human-centered design prioritizes the needs, desires, and experiences of human beings. Organizations that successfully adopt human-centered design outperform their peers in growth, including in revenue (Magalhães, 2020). In this new economic paradigm, value is derived from the memorable experiences organizations create for their customers rather than just the goods and services they provide.

This has had profound implications for how organizations think about their end users as consumers and their approach to work and the workplace.

1.4 The Changing Employee–Employer and Employee–Work Relationship

While human-centered design has commonly been used in marketing, service design, and technology, human resources (HR) practitioners have been slower in adopting it in people practices. A changeover would require a critical look at the processes and practices with which employees engage during their employment lifecycle. Organizations have to view them as consumers of people practices—consumers who have choice—and harness technology beyond efficiencies to deliver human-centered experiences at scale (Veldsman & Van der Merwe, 2022b).

The evolution of work and the rise of the human-centric movement have also redefined the psychological contract between employer and employee. The psychological contract is the unwritten set of expectations between employers and employees and goes beyond the formal employment contract (Karani Mehta et al., 2022). Traditionally, this contract was based on a simple exchange: Employees provided labor, and, in return, employers provided financial compensation and job security. However, as the nature of work evolved, so, too, did the psychological contract.

Today, the psychological contract encompasses a broader and more complex set of expectations. Employees now expect more than just a paycheck; they seek meaningful work, opportunities for growth, recognition, and a supportive work environment. Several factors have contributed to this development, including changes in workforce demographics, the rise of knowledge work, and increasing awareness of issues such as mental health, diversity, and inclusion. For example, Millennials and Generation Z, who represent a growing workforce, prioritize personal fulfillment and social impact in their careers, and they greatly value work–life balance (Deloitte, 2024).

Several factors have precipitated this move, including changing workforce demographics, the increasing importance of work–life balance, and the growing demand for transparency and authenticity from employers (De Araújo Vitória et al., 2022). The rise of purpose-driven organizations has also influenced the changing psychological contract. Employees increasingly seek to work for companies whose values are aligned with their own and who contribute to a greater social good (Deloitte, 2024). The changing dynamics in the relationship are illustrated in Fig. 1.1.

As a result, organizations must be intentional in designing experiences that align with these new expectations, and this is where EX plays a crucial role. Organizations are increasingly recognizing that, in order to attract and retain top talent, they must design work experiences that are engaging, fulfilling, and aligned with the values and expectations of their employees. A Gallup report (2024) found that